

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the seventh time on 9 June 2023.

Members noted the update provided by Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry about measures announced in the 2023–24 Budget with benefits for agriculture and processing sectors and their workers, including:

- investing up to \$4.1 billion in a new National Skills Agreement with states and territories, including supporting 300,000 Fee Free TAFE places from 2024-2026 in priority areas such as agriculture;
- investing \$370.8 million to further expand and improve the PALM scheme;
- improving pathways to permanency for Temporary Skill Shortage (TSS) (subclass 482) visa holders;
- providing \$75.8 million to extend the current surge in visa processing resources to ensure timely visa processing; and
- supporting access to essential services in our regions with a range of initiatives across early childcare, schooling, healthcare and housing.

Members discussed the importance of leveraging and complementing these measures through the efforts of the Working Group.

Members endorsed a new way of encouraging Australians, including in our cities, to consider careers in food and fibre, by outlining the critical contribution that agriculture makes to sustainable environmental management, food security and the Australian economy and agreed to support the work of AgriFutures Australia to develop a campaign promoting agricultural careers.

Members recognised that worker protection and the importance of compliance and enforcement activities have been key themes throughout the Working Group's activities. Members endorsed a range of actions they could take to support good employment practices as well as compliance and enforcement activities in the agriculture and related processing sectors.

Members discussed opportunities to enhance the workforce planning, data and evidence-base on agriculture and processing workforces. This included receiving a presentation from Professor Peter Dawkins, Director of Jobs and Skills Australia and his colleague Dr Damian Oliver, Assistant Secretary, Workforce Futures on Jobs and Skills Australia's role, engagement strategy and data.

Members reiterated their strong support for Jobs and Skills Australia to undertake a Food Supply Chain Workforce Capacity Study to provide an evidence-base to support better integration of the needs of the labour market, training and education system and the migration system for agriculture and processing sectors.

Members also welcomed the commitment of Dr Jared Greenville, Executive Director of ABARES, to undertake a range of actions to advance the state of agricultural workforce data and information, including:

- analysing the latest Census to produce an updated snapshot of the agriculture workforce as well as a report on longer term trends;
- generating new insights on the use of labour hire in the horticulture industry; and
- creating an agriculture workforce data front door on their website to help data users navigate available data.

Members also reflected on the new PALM scheme Approved Employer Deed and Guidelines. The PALM scheme has an important role in supporting agriculture and related processing sectors to meet their workforce needs. Industry and union members reflected their differing perspectives and anticipated outcomes for employers and workers. Members noted the importance of closely monitoring the implementation of the new changes to ensure the PALM scheme continues to deliver for all stakeholders.

Members also noted the update on action items being progressed through sub-groups focused on skills, migration, worker protection, inclusion and housing.

The Working Group will next meet in July 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Tony Mahar, CEO, National Farmers' Federation
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Joseph Mitchell, Assistant Secretary, Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- George Robertson, National Coordinator - Farms, United Workers Union
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-june-2023>